

book, *A Writer's People: Ways of Looking and Feeling*, is a personal testament. "My purpose in the book is not literary criticism or biography. I wish only, and in a personal way, to set out the writing to which I was exposed during my career." It is an extraordinary career, shaped by migration, struggle, memory and the pure wonderment of looking while seeing and listening while hearing. It began when, at the age of 18, he left Trinidad for Oxford on a scholarship. The university didn't teach him how to become a writer. In London, Somerset Maugham or Graham Greene or Henry James was not much of a help. As he began his career first as a BBC presenter for its Caribbean service and then as a reviewer for the *New Statesman* and *The Daily Telegraph*, deep within, the agony was about finding his own voice, his own narrative form.

He found them as he travelled to the dark interiors of the so-called half-made societies. He became the pitiless narrator of the trampled histories of a world let down by competing ideas of liberation. In his fictional works like *In a Free State*, *Guerrillas*, *A Bend in the River*, *A Way in the World*, we meet a writer for whom the world is a cheerless place, violent and unforgiving. A master of details, Naipaul places his novels in the real world, and they reduce the distance between imagination and superb reportage. As a writer he is never restricted by national boundaries; his freedom is accentuated by his existential status as an exile who doesn't miss home. When he remembers, there is no nostalgia. When he talks about his ancestry, there is no sentimentality. *A House for Mr Biswas* (1961), the novel that declared his arrival, is built on ancestral memory. The protagonist owes a great deal to the novelist's father, who was a journalist with *The Trinidad Guardian* and a 'failed' writer, nevertheless a pioneer.

The literary establishment, though, took a while to catch up with this prolific dissenter who has done nothing in his life except write. When the Swedish Academy finally gave the Nobel Prize to him "for having united perceptive narrative and incorruptible scrutiny in works that compel us to see the presence of suppressed histories", hard-core Naipaulites thought it was a belated recognition. There was irony in the timing; the Nobel was announced in October 2001, in the afterglow of 9/11. Naipaul, much to the displeasure of the Left-liberal establishment, has been writing and talking about the fantasies of Islam. *Among*

the Believers: An Islamic Journey (1981) and the sequel, *Beyond Belief: Islamic Excursions Among the Converted Peoples* (1998), both born out of his travels in Iran, Pakistan, Malaysia and Indonesia, bring out in ruthless precision how Islam as a religion of conversion destroys the past: "Islam in its origin is an Arab religion. Everyone not an Arab who is a Muslim is a convert. Islam is not simply a matter of conscience or private belief. It makes imperial demands..." The story of Pakistan, he said, is a "terror story". Much before radical Islamism came to dominate the glossary of post-9/11 world, Naipaul, never politically correct, was speaking the truth to a world of cosy illusions.

It was the same Naipaul who was caricatured as a closet Hindu nationalist when he saw the stirrings of a nationalist

revival in Indian politics when he talked about a ransacked past and civilisational vandalism. In the wake of the Gujarat riots, Salman Rushdie, provoked by his earlier anti-Muslim pronouncements, in an op-ed piece called him a "fellow traveller of fascism" who has disgraced the Nobel. That was nothing compared to what the other Nobel laureate from Trinidad said about him in verse. Derek Walcott wrote in a poem for "exiled novelists": "You spit on your people/your people applaud/your former oppressors laurel you/The thorns

biting your forehead/are contempt/disguised as concern/ still, you can come home, now." Naipaul was the one who went away, the chronicler of colonial imperfections who entered into a Faustian deal with the coloniser. He would return the compliment in *A Writer's People*, though with subtlety and elegance. The Empire may have shaped his formative years as a writer, but he is brutal in his rejoinder to the welfare state that has been eating away the British civilisation, as unravelled in *Magic Seeds*. The provocateur can't be bothered by his popularity rating.

Naipaul, at 75, doesn't have to win friends. Maybe he is too towering to be a friend. The Naipaul cult has only fanatic followers and awe-struck emulators. As he writes in *The Enigma of Arrival*, arguably his finest work, "in the wild garden and orchard beside the water meadows" of Wiltshire, he may have found the perfect English home. When the idyll is shattered by intrusive ghosts from a world he can't leave behind, he returns to the notebook, with a mischievous glint in his eyes. *A Writer's People* is such a writer's prerogative.

SECOND HOME: Naipaul with his wife Nadira in India



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